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Section Title(S): THE MANAGEMENT OF CONFLICT

These disputes are puzzling for their apparent lack of clear-cut outcomes. They flare up and die down without either party giving ground. The bubble of tension is often burst by a joke, which reduces the entire camp, including disputants, to helpless laughter. One is astonished to see two men chatting amicably together who only a few minutes before had been shouting abuse at one another. To a certain extent verbal battles appear to be a game played principally for the fun of laughing about it afterwards.

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Not all conflicts are dissipated so rapidly. More rancorous disputes may require the intervention of peacemakers to restore good relations, but several days later one or both parties packs up and leaves the camp. Much of the coming and going observed in Bushman camps can be traced to a recent history of strained relations. When an argument is too serious to be dissipated by rough good humor it is far simpler to split the camp than to stay together and fight it out. Old N!eisi explained it this way: "In the case of arguments in the camp, we sit down and talk it out, and bring in others who know more to listen. But with people like myself who don't want trouble, we will just pack up and go away."

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The Bushmen recognize three levels of conflict: talking (*n!wa*), fighting (*n!laie*), and killing (*n!waakwe*). They appear to delight in the first level and engage in it at every opportunity. But their dread of the second and third levels is extreme. The word *n!waakwe* means literally to "kill one another." Fighting as well is to be feared, since the act of homicide is well within the means of all adult men whose poisoned hunting arrows are always close at hand.

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The Bushmen are perhaps unusual among human societies in that they attach no value to fighting. They have no ideal of honor or of brave, aggressive masculinity. There are no culturally accepted outlets for physical violence, no wrestling matches, no games of strength, and no ordeals or duels in which a man can "prove" himself. The violent-tempered man and the proud man are sorry misfits among the !Kung, whose heroes are great curers and healers and not fighters.

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The extreme fear of violence among the !Kung by and large appears entirely justified: there have been some nasty "punch-ups" in the past and the !Kung have a reputation among their neighbors as fierce fighters. At least twenty-two homicides occurred among the !Kung during the period 1920–1955. The recent introduction of Tswana legal institutions has undoubtedly played an important part in controlling fighting. Today serious disputes are usually brought to the attention of the headman. In one recent case of adultery the aggrieved husband asked a neighboring Herero, "Are you going to take this matter over, or shall I do what is in my heart to do?" The Herero man, of course, interceded and brought the 361 principals to court. My impression is that the Tswana court has proved very successful because the Bushmen have been relieved to have an outside agent take the heavy responsibility of resolving conflicts out of their hands.

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